

Day 3 — The Six Darśanas

Module: What is IKS? (Senior) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students name the six classical philosophical schools (darśanas) and the central question each addresses.

Materials

- Whiteboard
- Reference card with the six darśanas

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Recall: what's the difference between Vedānga and Upaveda?

Core (25 min)

The Six Darśanas (classical philosophical systems, codified ~early CE):

#	Sanskrit	Central question	Founder/text
1	<i>Nyāya</i>	Logic & epistemology — what counts as valid knowledge?	Gautama, <i>Nyāya Sūtras</i>
2	<i>Vaiśeṣika</i>	Atomism & metaphysics — what categories of being exist?	Kaṇāda, <i>Vaiśeṣika Sūtras</i>
3	<i>Sāṅkhya</i>	Cosmology — what are the constituents of reality?	Kapila / Īśvarakṛṣṇa, <i>Sāṅkhya Kārikā</i> (4th c. CE)
4	<i>Yoga</i>	Practice — how does one settle the mind?	Patañjali, <i>Yoga Sūtras</i>
5	<i>Mīmāṃsā</i> (Pūrva)	Hermeneutics — how do we interpret the Veda?	Jaimini, <i>Mīmāṃsā Sūtras</i>
6	<i>Vedānta</i> (Uttara Mīmāṃsā)	Metaphysics — what is the ultimate?	Bādarāyaṇa, <i>Brahma Sūtras</i> ; Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja, Madhva (later interpreters)

Note: these are often called the *āstika* schools (those that accept Vedic authority). The *nāstika* schools (Buddhism, Jainism, Cārvāka) developed in parallel — different intellectual traditions also “Indian,” not “IKS” by the conservative definition. Be explicit about this boundary choice.

Sāṅkhya and Yoga as a pair — closely related; Sāṅkhya provides the metaphysics (25 tattvas — see Module 2 Senior), Yoga provides the practice. You met Sāṅkhya in Module 2 (Panchabhuta) and will meet Yoga in Module 8.

Nyāya's contribution to logic. The Nyāya system developed sophisticated logical analysis — formal arguments (*anumāna*), categorical syllogisms, debate procedures (*tarka*). Influenced modern logic via early-20th-c. Indian logicians (especially Bimal Krishna Matilal's work in the 1960s).

Discussion (10 min)

- Which darśana would address each question?
 - “What does it mean to know something?” → Nyāya
 - “Why does my mind keep wandering?” → Yoga
 - “How should we read the Veda?” → Mīmāṃsā
 - “What is the relationship between the individual self and ultimate reality?” → Vedānta
 - “What are matter's smallest units?” → Vaiśeṣika

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 4: “Tomorrow — Indian mathematics in specifics. Bakhshali, Bhāskara, Mādhava.”

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Matilal, B. K. (1986). *Perception: An Essay on Classical Indian Theories of Knowledge*. Oxford.
- **Tier down:** Memorise the 6 names + central question of each.

Teacher notes

- The “āstika vs nāstika” distinction is important. Buddhism and Jainism are ENORMOUS Indian intellectual traditions excluded from a narrow “IKS” definition. Honest scholarship acknowledges this.

Citation(s) used

- Olivelle (1996, ed.) on the Upanishadic background.
- Matilal (1986) for Nyāya logic.
- Bryant (2009) for Yoga.